

Evidence Brief | Spotlight Series No. 2

*This brief draws on the presentation 'From Designing the Missing Operating System for Climate-Health Action in Africa' Presented by Dr. Maqo Eric Gatto (Group CEO, Development Dynamics Kenya) at the second CAPCHA Spotlight Webinar Series Themed. **When Evidence Exists but Policy Doesn't Move.***

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Africa has no shortage of climate–health evidence. Research institutions, practitioners, and regional initiatives continue to generate knowledge that can inform policy, while continental bodies are strengthening climate and health action. Yet despite this growing evidence base, policy uptake and implementation remain slow. The challenge is no longer producing more evidence, but understanding why existing evidence so often fails to reach and influence policy and decision-making. The bottleneck lies in governance: the systems, institutions, and processes that determine how evidence moves into decisions, financing, and implementation.

The Missing Layer: Why Evidence Struggles to Move

Five key barriers prevent evidence from driving policy and decision-making. These include fragmented institutional ownership, which leaves responsibility unclear; a translation gap, where research is not presented as actionable policy options; weak links between evidence and financing; limited inclusion of community, practitioner, Indigenous, and frontline knowledge, reducing legitimacy and uptake; and poor institutional memory, which causes lessons and decisions to be repeatedly lost across leadership and policy transitions.

Building an Operating System for Climate–Health Action

To address these barriers, effective climate–health governance requires five core functions: clear institutional ownership and accountability, translation of evidence into practical policy tools, sustained coordination mechanisms, inclusive and trust-based decision-making, and strong institutional memory to preserve knowledge and ensure continuity. These functions enable evidence to move beyond research and into policy and implementation.

From Evidence to Action: A Five-Stage Pathway

The 5-stage pathway framework identifies where evidence-to-policy processes break down and strengthens the pathway from knowledge generation to implementation. It is built around five core functions: generating evidence, translating it into actionable decisions, assigning clear ownership, linking recommendations to sustainable financing, and implementing actions through continuous learning and adaptation. Recognising that evidence alone does not drive change, the framework emphasises the need to clearly define who should act, where decisions are made, how implementation will be enabled, and how progress will be monitored. Grounded in systems thinking and participatory approaches, it also underscores the importance of evidence synthesis, innovation, and sustainable financing to bridge the persistent gap between research and long-term climate and health policy action.

Beyond Individual Organizations: Understanding Collective Impact

Meaningful policy change depends on collective impact rather than individual action. While organizations generate valuable evidence, lasting influence emerges when they connect through networks, communities of practice, and broader movements that align around shared goals. These relationships create an ecosystem where knowledge is exchanged, strengthened, and translated into policy and systems change. The key lesson is that evidence does not shape policy simply by existing, it becomes influential when supported by the relationships, institutions, and governance structures that move it into action.

What This Means for Decision Makers

Moving climate–health evidence into policy requires more than generating research; it requires governance systems that connect evidence to decisions, financing, implementation, and accountability. Evidence must be translated into clear policy actions, with defined ownership, coordination, and institutional learning. This also raises a fundamental governance question: who shapes priorities, whose knowledge informs decisions, and who benefits? Strengthening African-led, equitable systems that value local knowledge and community participation is essential to ensure that evidence does not stop at publication but drives meaningful policy and action.